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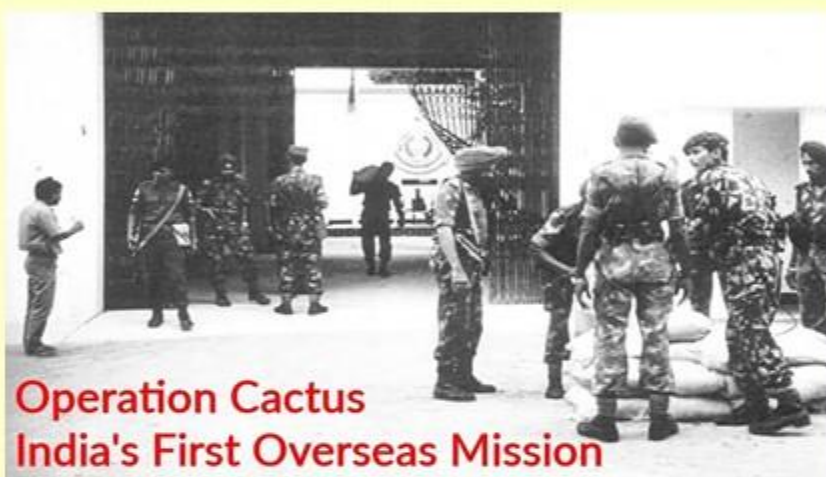
Learning Space

NEWSPAPER

8th February, 2018

ITEM WISE EDITORIALS

6th WEEK



OPERATION CACTUS & MALDIVES

UPSC CSE – GS II

GS II ... INDIA AND ITS NEIGHBOURHOOD-RELATIONS, EFFECT OF POLICIES AND POLITICS OF DEVELOPED AND DEVELOPING COUNTRIES ON INDIA'S INTERESTS.

6

Drama on the high seas, 30 years ago

'Operation Cactus', India's swift intervention in the Maldives, was riveting till the end



SUSHIL KUMAR

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In the war room

With drama unfolding on the high seas, the Indian Navy War Room in New Delhi was tense, monitoring every move there was Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi. The Swiss Ambassador to India was also there as one of the hostages, and the only woman was a Swiss national (the mother-in-law of the Minister mentioned earlier). The mission before the Navy's Task Force Commander was certainly difficult – to rescue the hostages without a scratch and capture the rebels.

As dawn broke the next day, the rebels were startled to see the imposing warships that had stealthily encircled their ship during the night. Confused and agitated, they refused to negotiate and tried to steam ahead, full speed. Their intent was to seek refuge in

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Sushil Kumar was Director of Naval Operations in 1988, and later Chief of the Indian Navy



Tread Softly On Maldives

India's response to Yameen's seizure of power must rely on smarts, not brawn

Indrani Bagchi #Timesgroup.com



Maldives is back in the grip of another internal crisis. President Abdulla Yameen, a thinly veiled autocrat, has thrown a blanket of emergency on the island nation after the Supreme Court ordered the release and retrial of 12 high profile political prisoners including a former president and veep. The Chief Justice is behind bars as is Yameen's half-brother and former President Maumoon Abdul Gayoom. Others will likely follow, as Yameen seems hell bent on populating his prisons with his opponents.

There are calls for India to "act". Why should we not be a big power and show muscle in the shape of warships and fighters to cut panda-hugging Yameen down to size? A reprise of Op Cactus? Or sanctions? Something, anything!

India would be monumentally stupid to take any of these actions at present. Maldives has been in a state of low level instability for some time, affecting its economy and polity. Maldives's internal problems only hurt itself for the time being – with international tourism as its economic mainstay and a growing problem of Islamist jihadist cadres, Yameen's manoeuvrability is not great and he knows it. In fact, as Maldives approaches general elections later this year Yameen will run out of space, literally and politically.

Mohamed Nashood, former president and an equally opportunistic politician, is calling for an "Indian envoy, backed by its military" to help remove Yameen. However, it would be in India's interest to tread softly and allow the internal crisis to play itself out – albeit, with some help.

An outside power attempting regime change by force is no longer an option this century; it is likely to have the opposite effect. It could consolidate public opinion behind Yameen and ramp up nationalist fervour, giving his actions greater acceptability. Yameen's profound distrust of India would do the rest, and we would have truly lost Maldives.



We can jump into another country to save it from itself. But if the US war in Iraq and Syria – and India's own misadventure in Sri Lanka – has taught us anything, it is that when we embark on gunboat diplomacy, two things generally happen – we lose control of our fate because we get tangled in their internal dynamics; secondly, all their troubles and vices become ours.

Instead, this is the time to adopt the Deng Xiaoping method of stonewall – tread softly and carry a big stick. India has many big sticks in its arsenal, it would do well to play them smartly not muscularly.

The Chief Justice's 'lawfare' against Yameen did not happen out of the blue – we would do well to remember that Abdulla Saheed and Yameen had bonded on their common dislike for Nashood in the first place. Now he is the poster boy for Yameen's dictatorial craziness, as is 80-year-old Gayoom, a quasi-autocrat himself for over 30 years. This means even among the few who are not in jail

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Yameen is under international fire from the US and UK – even the mild-mannered UN has seen fit to call him out. That should continue. Germany, Saudi Arabia and France should add their voices. We need more travel advisories and cautionary notes from around the world – a hit on tourism should be the first

international thumbs down on Yameen's actions, not stopping medical visas to Maldivians. The political point we make with Pakistan is unnecessary here.

It would be an equal mistake to view events in South Asia as a zero-sum proxy war between India and China. China's presence in South Asia is a reality – deal with it. But China put out its travel advisory (Chinese tourists form over 30% of Maldives' arrivals) even before India's. China likes dictators, especially corrupt ones, but it did not take the one step that would have shown its unconditional support of Yameen.

In Zimbabwe, Sri Lanka, North Korea and Myanmar, China is learning the hard way that while countries welcome Chinese money and assistance, which gives them wiggle room against powers like India, they are shifty about too deep a presence. KP Oli, who has just returned to power on an anti-India platform in Nepal, is busy burning up phone lines with "stakeholders" in India to say how and why he is not a Chinese agent.

New Delhi and Oli may not like each other, but foreign minister Sushma Swaraj's visit showed India is learning. For good reasons and bad, Oli and India will find that modus vivendi.

Part of the belief that India should fly in a C-130 filled with soldiers into Male is an institutional arrogance that has not served it well in the neighbourhood, witness the disastrous 2015 blockade in Nepal. There is equal danger of making a strategic error if we lock ourselves into a binary reaction because of China, and fail to use our own tools to exercise power, our way.

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7th February, 2018

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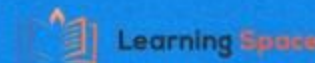


UPSC CSE – GS II

GS II ... India and its neighbourhood-relations, Effect of policies and politics of developed and developing countries on India's interests.

THE HINDU
INDIA'S NATIONAL NEWSPAPER SINCE 1878

8th February, 2018



MORE ABOUT MALDIVES

**Maumoon Abdul Gayoom**

President,
1978 - 2008

**Mohamed Nasheed**

President, 2008-2012
(He was convicted under anti-terror law
and sentenced to 13 years in prison and he
is at present in exile)

**Abdulla Yameen**

President (since 2013 ...),
who is accused of stifling
human rights

- *Tourism is the mainstay of Maldives economy and it is suffering badly because of political instability.*
- *India is treading cautiously.*



NEWS REPORT

- The political crisis in Maldives deepens.
- The Opposition Leader calls for India to step in and help resolve the situation.
- The opposition leader also asked India to send an envoy backed by the Country's military to release the Judges and political prisoners.
- He requested for a physical presence.
- Now, India decided to restrain itself to a statement that India is "closely monitoring" the evolving situation in Maldives.

WHAT DO YOU UNDERSTAND BY OPERATION CACTUS?



ABDUL GAYOOM
FORMER MALDIVIAN PRESIDENT



- 1 There was a similar call in 1988, when the then Maldivian President Abdul Gayoom sought India's help.
- 2 This is the only time New Delhi intervened in the affairs of Male.
- 3 There was an attempted coup by mercenaries against the then President Gayoom.
- 4 The coup was carried out by Sri Lankan Tamil Militants on behalf of the Maldivian Businessman.

WHAT DO YOU UNDERSTAND BY OPERATION CACTUS?



- 5** On November 3, 1988, the Presidential Palace was taken under seize and the Maldivian Businessman Abdullah Luthufi installed himself in the President's Chair.
- 6** The Foreign Minister made a call to several countries seeking help.
- 7** The then Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi dispatched 1,600 troops within 9 hrs to Maldives and within hours order was restored in the Country.

This was known as "Operation Cactus"

WHY 2018 IS DIFFERENT FROM 1988?



Now, in the changed circumstances, India should move cautiously. That is the precise reason, why India is exercising restraint.

- 1 China has got huge presence –
 - FTA with Maldives
 - Decision of Maldives to lease the islands
 - Infrastructure development in Maldives by China.
- 2 If India interferes, there is every chance that it may lead to nationalistic sentiments in Maldives. It would become counterproductive and the people may rally behind the present authoritarian President.
- 3 In Nepal, India had a very bad experience, where the nationalistic sentiment was aroused because of the blockade at the border by the Madhesis and it was felt that they were supported by India.

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